



Resilient effort: For South Zone, it was left to the lone spinner Ankit Sharma to wage a solitary fight — six wickets in the match and a fighting 168-ball 99 that pulled his side clear of danger. K. MURALIKUMAR

bounds for spectators. Several cricket fans working in nearby factories and warehouses turned up in support but were denied entry by security staff.

Lack of atmosphere

The BCCI must address this urgently, as keeping fans away robs the sport of a core element.

As a result, matches were played in silence, without the usual buzz. Apart from the final, no matches were telecast live, further deflating the tournament's presence.

The pitches across both grounds were absolute batting belters, reducing contests to mammoth run-scoring exercises. Even the final, between eventual champion Central Zone and South Zone, lost some shine when six players were withdrawn after being named in the India 'A' squad to face Australia 'A'.

South lost N. Jagadeesan and Devdutt Padikkal, while Central was without Khaleel Ahmed, Yash Thakur, Harsh Dubey and Manav Suthar.

Thanks to India's vast talent pool, replacements were not hard to find. One such was Ankit Sharma, drafted into the South squad for the final. The left-handed all-rounder made his senior debut for Madhya Pradesh in

2009 and even shared a dressing room with Dale Steyn, Kumar Sangakkara and Shikhar Dhawan at now-defunct Deccan Chargers in the 2012 IPL. Now 34 and representing Puducherry, Ankit has long been away from the IPL spotlight. Yet his performance in the final showed his career is far from over. He produced a fighting 168-ball 99, rescuing South from a precarious situation, and also claimed six wickets across two innings with his left-arm spin, albeit in a losing cause.

Ankit shone in a brilliant 192-run partnership with Andre Siddarth, another late South Zone replacement. The Tamil Nadu youngster displayed admirable temperament in his unbeaten 84 under mounting pressure.

Making a mark

Sarangsh Jain (in pic), meanwhile, seized his chance to impress national selectors. With 16 wickets and two handy fifties, the Central all-rounder was named 'Player of the Series'.

Sarangsh is a rarity in Indian First-Class cricket — a spinner who can consistently land the



Brief scores (Final)

Central Zone 511 (Rathod 194, Patidar 101, Jain 69, Gurjapneet 4-124) and 66 for 4 (Wadkar 19*, Rathod 13*, Gurjapneet 2-21) beat South Zone 149 (Tanmay 31, Jain 5-49, Kartikeya 4-53) and 426 (Ankit 99, Siddarth 84*, Kartikeya 4-110, Jain 3-130) by six wickets

ball on a good line and length. The 32-year-old from Madhya Pradesh tested batters with discipline and often came out on top.

His teammate Kumar Kartikeya also made a statement in the final. The versatile left-arm spinner, capable of bowling both orthodox and wrist spin depending on the match-up, had been overlooked for the earlier rounds, as well as the past two seasons.

A match-winning eight-wicket haul, achieved with clever flight and variation, was a timely reminder of his class.

Whether Ankit, Andre, Sarangsh and Kartikeya are rewarded with bigger roles remains to be seen.

South coach and former India pacer L. Balaji, however, underlined the tournament's enduring significance. Balaji recalled that he made his India comeback on the strength of Duleep Trophy performances. "The international and domestic schedules are packed nowadays. We also have State leagues. But still players are giving it their maximum to play here," Balaji said.

"The Duleep Trophy has been one of the major tournaments. The recognition for it has always been high. It is an iconic tournament. Good performances here can earn a place in the India 'A' team. I made my India comeback in 2005 after taking wickets in the Duleep Trophy.

I am sure that the Duleep Trophy will get the recognition it deserves," he added.

